

Panic attacks and phobias

A panic attack is when intense anxious feelings come on very suddenly. Similar feelings of overwhelming anxiety can also be triggered by the fear of something specific, known as a phobia.

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Panic attacks

Panic attacks are feelings of extreme anxiety that come on in unpredictable attacks. They may cause a sufferer to feel as if they're about to faint, have a heart attack, or die. A panic attack usually lasts for about 10 minutes. The feelings gradually go away without causing any harm, but a sufferer can feel exhausted afterward.

Panic attacks can happen for no apparent reason, or be caused by a trigger, though the reason may not always be clear. If a teen has had an attack at a particular place and time, being in the same situation again might trigger another.

TEEN HINTS

Helping a friend

- Stay calm yourself. Don't rush them; reassure and remind them it will pass. Never say "pull yourself together" or "get over it."
- Get them to focus on their breathing. Ask them to breathe in and out slowly. Do it with them and count in for three, and out for three.
- March on the spot with them to release stress, or ask them to name five things they can see around them.



△ **Jumping or racing heart.**



△ **Shaking, sweating, or trembling.**



△ **Dizziness or nausea.**



△ **Ringing in ears or sensitivity to noise.**



△ **Difficulty breathing normally.**



△ **Tingling hands and feet.**

△ **Panic attack symptoms**

The symptoms might feel scary, but they will not cause any physical harm.

Reducing the risk of panic attacks

There are ways to help reduce the likelihood of a panic attack:

Realize

- A panic attack is caused by the body's "fight or flight" response, evolved by all animals, including humans, to protect themselves when confronted with danger.
- The symptoms are scary, but they won't cause any physical harm.

Be prepared

- Plan how to respond if an attack happens. Then, if one is about to start, or if a trigger situation occurs, there is a routine and everyone knows what to do.

Slow down

- Try breathing exercises, as well as meditation and mindfulness (focusing on the present moment).
- Have calming music available that can be accessed quickly.